

Election expenditures should be strictly monitored, black money banned, and the property of those found to have benefited from misuse of power should be liable to forfeiture.

Third, we need to set up institutional mechanisms to identify those who misuse their power for private purposes. Transparency reduces the space for corruption. The right to information is an important step in that direction, but it is not enough. Citizens should also have the right to know who took what decisions, how and why. We should have an ombudsman in every major government department with the responsibility to help citizens secure necessary information. State legislatures and Lok Sabha should have powerful select committees cross examining ministers, civil servants and other public figures and conducting public hearings of the kind that the US Senate does.

Fourth, effective and expeditious punishment of those found guilty or under strong suspicion. At present, barely 6 per cent of corruption related cases lead to conviction. This is unacceptable. If we can find ways of severely punishing even a few major politicians found guilty of misusing their political power, it would set a wonderful example to the rest of the country and do much to restore its confidence in our system.

Finally, we should consolidate and strengthen our civil society. India is rightly respected as the NGO capital of the world. We have a long tradition of citizens actively organising themselves in the pursuit of worthy public causes and standing up to the state. In every town and city as well as at the national level, we need to set up powerful citizens' organisations to keep an eye on our public and private institutions, to offer legal, administrative and political support to victims of injustices, and in general to act as the guardians of our public norms. This is similar to what Mahatma Gandhi had in mind when he urged the setting up of the Lok Sevak Sangh.

We once had wonderfully humorous ways



**Gandhigiri grows:**  
Volunteers feticitating  
traffic rule violators in Pune

of deflating the pompous politicians and firmly putting them in their place. We need to revive these. People could attend politicians' meetings with placards that lampoon them and proclaim their misdeeds, interrupt them with good-natured but hard-hitting slogans, or adopt other forms of Gandhigiri. Jawaharlal Nehru was rattled when a crowd outside his meeting started shouting, *Congress raj ki kya pehchan, bhookha nanga Hindustan* (What's Congress rule? Hungry and naked India). Tony Blair never recovered his confidence when faced with placards calling him 'Bliar'. And Lyndon Johnson was moved to tears when during the Vietnam War, young university students shouted such slogans as "Hi hi LBJ, how many kids did you kill today?" It is about time we turned laughter into a lethal political weapon.

Traditional societies have their own ways of enforcing their cultural norms. When the state comes on the scene with modernity, traditional mechanisms no longer work. We need to evolve a new culture, appropriate to the modern impersonal state. The way in which Western societies—after a long struggle against corruption—developed, the modern civic and political culture has important lessons for us, which we ignore at our peril.

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## Moral Code

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